

Hazrat Yunus

Hazrat Yunus in the Qur'ān

In the Qur'ān Hazrat Yunus  is mentioned in six *surahs*: *Surah Nisaa*, *Surah An'aam*, *Surah Yunus*, *Surah al-Saffaat*, *Surah Ambiyaa* and *Surah al-Qalam*. In the first four of these only the name is mentioned and in the later two *Surahs* he is referred to as *Zun Noon* (The Man of the Fish) and *Saahibul Hoot* "the Companion of the Fish." In *Surah Nisa* and *An'aam* his name is only mentioned as him being one of the prophets whereas in other *Surahs* a little light is thrown on his history, but mention is only made of the prophetic aspect of his life which focussed on him being a bringer of spiritual guidance.

The Qur'ān states in *Surah Yunus*:

"Why was there not a single township (among those we warned) who believed—So its faith should here profited it—except the people of Yunus. When they believed we removed from them the penalty of ignominy In the life of the present and permitted them to enjoy their life for a while.

And further:

"And remember *Zun Noon* when he departed in wrath. He imagined that we will not cause narrowness over him. But he cried through the darkness. "There is no God but You. Glory to you. I was indeed wrong."

So we listened to him and delivered him from distress and thus do we deliver those who have faith.

And further:

"And verily Yunus was among those sent by us. Remember when he ran away (like a slave from captivity) to the ship (fully) laden,
He agreed to cast lots and he was condemned. Then the big fish did swallow him up
And he had done things worthy of blame
Had it not been that he (repented) and glorified Allah
He would certainly have remained in side the fish till the day of Resurrection
But We cast him forth on the naked shore in a state of sickness
And we caused to grow over him a spreading plant of the gourd kind. And we sent him (on a mission) to a hundred thousand or more and they believed. So we permitted them to enjoy there life for a while."
(37:139—149)

And Lastly:

"So (O Muhammad) wait with patience for the command of your Lord, and be not like the companion of the fish, when he cried out in

agony. Had not grace from His Lord reached him, he would have been cast off on the naked shore, in disgrace.

Thus did his Lord choose him and make him of the company of the righteous." (68:48)

In *Surah Ambiya* Hazrat Yunus عليه السلام is called "Zun Noon" because in ancient Arabic a fish was called 'Noon' whereas in *Surah al-Qalam* he is called 'Saahib-ul-Hoof' because 'Hoof' is also a name for a fish. Because he had an incident with a fish in his life he is called the 'companion of the fish'.

His Lineage and Era

According to Bukhari Shareef in a report by Abdullah bin Abbaas رضي الله عنه, his father's name is mentioned as being 'Mataa.' The Christian and Jews know him as Jonah and his father as Amtay.

As for the era in which he lived, Bukhari in his *Kitaabul Ambiyaa* has placed him in the period between Hazrat Musa عليه السلام, Hazrat Shuaib عليه السلام and Hazrat Dawood عليه السلام.

According to Shah Abdul Qader, Hazrat Yunus عليه السلام was a contemporary of Hazrat Hizkeel عليه السلام. Ibn Hajar says it is very difficult to fix the historical era of Hazrat Yunus عليه السلام. Maulana Hifzur Rahman is of the opinion that the view of Hazrat Shah Abdul Qader appears to be correct. And Allah knows best.

Place of His Mission

Hazrat Yunus عليه السلام was chosen and sent for the guidance of the inhabitants of the famous city of Iraq—Ninewa. This was the old Assyrian capital and was near the present city of Mosul. The Qur'aan mentions that the inhabitant of the city numbered over a hundred thousand.

His Death

Shah Abdul Qader states that Nabi Yunus عليه السلام passed away in the very city to where he was sent and that he is buried there in Ninewa. This opinion is correct.

The Virtue of Yunus عليه السلام

According to some *Hadith* Rasulallah ﷺ spoke very well of Hazrat Yunus عليه السلام. In one *Hadith* he said: "None of you should ever say that I am better than Yunus bin Mataa."

Abu Hurairah رضي الله عنه reports that Jew once was selling some goods. A person bought something and wanted to pay for it. The price which the Jew wanted did not suit him. He offered less. The Jew said: "I swear by Him who made Musa the best of all men, that I will never sell this thing to you for that price."

An Ansari heard this and become so angry that he smacked the Jew a blow through the face, saying: "Do you say such a thing while the prophet of Allah is among us?"

The Jew immediately proceeded to the presence of Rasulallah ﷺ to lay a complaint, saying: "O Abul Qasim, when there is an agreement between us and you, how is it that this Muslim has smacked me?"

Rasulallah ﷺ then asked the Ansari to explain the reason for the smack and as the Ansari told the story the face of Rasulallah ﷺ became red with anger.

He said: "Do not grant excellence to some prophets over others, because on the day of *Qiyaamat* when the first bugle shall be blown, every one on earth will become unconscious except those whom Allah will exempt. Then the bugle will be blown a second time and all will began consciousness. The first to wake up will be I. Then I will see Musa عليه السلام standing

near the Throne of Allah. I cannot say whether he woke up before me or whether he was saved from becoming unconscious. And I cannot even say that any prophet is more excellent than Yunus bin Mataa."

In these *Hadith* Yunus is personally mentioned. In the second *Hadith* it is said: "Do not grant excellence to some prophets over others. This shows outwardly there should be no higher rank for some over others. What is the truth of this statement and its reality?"

By way of clarification we quote another verse from the Qur'ān Allah says: "Those Messengers we endowed with gifts some above others." This shown that Allah has created ranks among the prophets and messenger, some above others and some enjoy virtues above others.

Rasulullah ﷺ is reported to have said: "I am the pride of the children of Adam ﷺ. (And I say this) with out boasting."

Then on the other hand he also said:

"Do not grant excellence to some prophets above others. And let none of you ever say I am better than Yunus bin Matta."

Now comes the question: Is there any reconciliation between these statements? The answer is this: Undoubtedly there are various ranks of excellence between the prophets and no doubt whatsoever that Rasulullah Muhammad ﷺ is the most excellent of all. But then what about his prohibition of granting excellence to some over others? The answer to this is that it is completely prohibited to grant excellence to any Nabi in such a way that the one over whom excellence is granted is made to appear inferior. In other words out of love for a specific prophet one should not praise him to such an extent that other prophets are made to look inferior. That

is something that could result in *Kufr* as is bound to happen when a debate situation arises.

Lessons and Warnings

1. With regard to the guidance of people it is Allah's *Sunnat* that when they turn their backs on the prophet's invitations and continue to reject his call, while persisting with their wrong-doing, the prophet becomes disappointed with their rejection and warns them of Allah's punishment, then in such a case there only one of two ways out of the predicament: They can either believe and declare their faith before the punishment descends upon them to save themselves from punishment. Or they can become the victims of Allah's punishment. It is not possible that they should still refuse to believe and still be saved from the wrath of Allah.

The history of the peoples of Nooh ﷺ, Saulih ﷺ, Loot ﷺ, Aad and Thamood etc., and other previous nations with their grand civilizations and achievement were so suddenly destroyed in spite of their great strengths and powerful structures that Allah's punishment causes them all to perish and this is adequate evidence of Allah's punishment which destroys.

2. Among the previous nations the people of Nabi Yunus ﷺ is an example of a nation that declared its faith before the punishment could come over them, who became truly obedient and so was saved from punishment. If only nations coming after them decided to follow their example and so saved themselves from punishment. But this did not happen.

3. The manner in which Allah treats his prophets differs very much from His manner of Treating the ordinary person. This should be so because Allah how honoured those prophets by speaking to them directly and converting with them. Therefore the implementing of the commands of Allah is a greater responsibility upon them and they intend to do everything in accordance with revelation, especially conveying the message of truth.

Therefore which they act hastily or acts without awaiting guidance from Allah's Revelation, then even if the matter seems insignificant, Allah calls them to account in a harsh manner that those who hear about it would imagine that they were guilty of a great crime. But at the same time Allah's help stays with them and they soon show sorrow and regret, begging for forgiveness and pardon, which is soon accepted by Allah and becomes a means of increase in honour and respect.

In the style of the Qur'ān this is a very important manner. And there who are unaware of the truth will find these kinds of incidents quite filled with anxiety, because on the one side they see Allah calling a certain personality a *Nabi* or a *Rasul*, praising him and on the other side we see that same person treated as if he is guilty of a heinous crime and sin. The causes quite a bit of confusion. For this reason it is necessary that the above point should always be kept in mind when studying the events of the prophets.

4. It is the teaching of Islām that every *Nabi* of Allah is a *Nabi* of Islām, irrespective to which *Deen* he belongs and as such it is necessary to believe in him just as one believes in the Prophet ﷺ is the most excellent of all prophets, it is prohibited to praise him in such a manner

that from this praising it becomes clear that one goes an inferior position to any other prophet, as often happens in the *Meelaad* gatherings.

Note: The *Tafseer* of the *Mufasssireen* as regards the events of the life of Hazrat Yunus عليه السلام as it appears in the Qur'ān and the differences of opinion among them deal especially with the meanings of words and their etymology and these have not been dealt with in this discussion.

QASASUL AMBIYAA

STORIES OF THE PROPHETS

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Rah.)



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Qasasul Ambiyaa

(Stories of the Prophets)

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Qasasul Ambiyaa

The Holy Qur'ān does not relate historical facts merely for the sake of telling a story which is of historical value. Its main aim in relating happenings is to draw attention to the results, conclusions and deductions from these incidents so that they become a source of guidance for men and prove to be lessons for them that appeal to their minds and emotions that from these historical events, lessons should be derived. These lessons should convince them that the existence of Allah is an undeniable fact and that His Mighty Hand is playing a major role in the affairs of men. It should also bring to their notice that to follow the stipulations of His deen brings success and leads to salvation and is the way towards all progress. That is what Islām—the natural religion—is about.

From: Qasasul Qur'ān

Preface

The most authentic and comprehensive work of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy, *Qasasul Qur'ān* needs no introduction. However, the Manner in which our friend Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version of a voluminous and bulky work he has undoubtedly, fulfilled one of the needs of this time. He has adopted such a method of abridgement whereby not only has he retained and mentioned every important fact in the lives of the Holy Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and other saintly personalities, which are of lessons to men, but also discussed in brought outline some other important matters. It is hoped that with Allah's grace, those persons who are occupied and busy at all times, will be able to derive adequate benefit from this work.

The great effort of Sayed Tanzeem Hussain in this old age of his is really something praiseworthy. May Allah reward him well for this great effort.

Qari Sayed Rasheedul-Hasan Hussainy Nadwi

Imam and Khateeb

Jama Masjid, New Town

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P5 Muharram, 1308 Hijri

Publisher's Foreword

The respected personality of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy is one of the most eminent Ulama of the Indo-Pak Sub-Continent. His most approved and well-known book, *Qasasul-Qur'ān* is considered to be a unique publication on this subject. The point that distinguishes it from other similar books is the fact that after every story, Maulana has made use of deep thought and reflection to present to the readers the lessons and points of guidance from the related episodes. Thus for the teachers and lecturers at *Deeni Madressas* and for preachers in mosques and students of deen the study and perusal of this book is of utmost benefit.

The original book appeared in four volumes with over 1800 pages of subject matter. Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version there of in only 600 pages and this has been met with a verdict of approval from all academic circles, especially by virtue of the fact that he has fulfilled one of the most pressing needs of the time and by leaving aside unimportant discussions have given the busy and occupied ones also a chance to benefit from these work. May Allah reward him well.

Author's Foreword

All praise be to Allah who has guided us with the Holy Book and revealed to us the Qur'ān in a clear Arabic language and in it. He related the best of stories as an admonition and a reminder for the believers. And May peace and blessings be upon the Most truthful and trustworthy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the messenger of Allah and seal of all the Prophets and upon his offspring, and companions who were all of them guiding stars for all the righteous ones.

Among the inimitable ways in which Allah has chosen for the sake of the guidance of men, is this that attention is drawn to the good and bad deeds of nations and the resultant fruits of such deeds of which they are reminded so that those deeds may be a lesson for men. For this reason those stories are not being related in a style as is generally done in history. The major aim is to convey the truth and to invite to Allah and with this in mind attention is only drawn to those aspects which furthers this objective. For this reason there is constant repetition so that these events can sink into the hearts and minds of listeners and they become attentive towards them. This sinking in and attentiveness can only be achieved if the same event is repeated in various ways and styles whereby sleeping faculties are woken up.

The Qur'ānic stories and events deal mostly with previous nations and the Messengers of Allah (*Alaihimus*

Salām) who were sent to them and bit by bit other matters also become included there-in, mostly dealing with the arguments over good and bad and the battles between the friends of Allah and the friends of *Shaitan*, which in itself proves to be a great lesson and admonishment for me.

But, leaving others aside, there are today so few Muslims who derive benefit from Allah's last and perfect law-book, the Qur'ān, to fill our hearts with *Iman* and *Yaqeen*. After all it is Allah's law and we are commanded to implement its orders in our lives, Moreover we are required to ponder over its meanings as this Qur'ān is the means forwards acquiring success and salvation in both this world and the here after.

At the time of the Revelation of the Qur'ān, the Messenger of Allah became so distressed and defected at the enmity and opposition of the polytheists that he raised this complaint to Allah:

(5:25—30)

However, in this 15th century, if we should examine our hearts, we will find that in spite of our claims to be Muslims and believing the Qur'ān to be the word of Allah, how few are who have made this word of Allah the pattern for their lives and the model on which to base their lives, who read and recited with this aim in mind?

It was my aim, seeing this condition of my people and myself, to translate this great source of admonition into Urdu so that by presenting the translated version, the hearts of people will automatically become drawn to the original i.e., the Qur'ān and thereby acquire everlasting happiness.

In spite of my simple style of writing, care has been taken to confine myself to a few special points.

- (a) In this book the basis for all the stories is the Holy Qur'ān and the authentic *Hadith* and these have been further elucidated with historical facts.
- (b) Where there appears any contradiction or differences in the stories as told in the old testament and the Qur'ān, then with clear arguments an effort has been made either to reconcile the versions or with clear arguments to prove the truth as is expounded in the Qur'ān.
- (c) An effort has been made to point out the nonsensical Israili stories and where there have been nonsensical objections from enemies, these have in the light of the true facts been made clear for what they are.
- (d) In some special places there have been introduced some discussions on matters of disputes in *Tafseer* and *Hadith* and after discussing these the views of the saintly elders have been mentioned as a solution.
- (e) The facts concerning every Prophet ﷺ and in which chapter of the Qur'ān they are mentioned, has been gathered in one place.
- (f) Lastly, together with all the above points, a special heading of "Results and lessons", is introduced, giving the actual objective of this book and its main purpose viz., admonition and warning. Special attention is drawn to this aspect.

Servant of the Millat

Muhammad Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy

22 Rajab, 1360 Hijri

Translator's Foreword

For me as the translator of this book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman is a great honour. Throughout my student days in Darul Uloom Deoband in India, Maulana Hifzur Rahman or as we know him then as the *Mujahid-e-Millat* was one of the most respected leaders of the Muslim community. We used to flock to listen to his most interesting lectures. And as the general secretary of the *Jamiatul-Ulama*, and a M.P. he was also a great 'Alim (scholar) as can be gauged from this book *Qasasul Ambiya* (Tales of the Prophets) which entailed great research. I can remember whenever the students were confronted with any problem in the lives of any of the prophets, they always took refuge in Maulana's book for answers. I took upon it as a great honour in being in some small manner associated with Maulana's scholarship, even though this is an abridged version of the original book. But I must also state that I found great difficulty in translating this book because of the exceptionally high quality of the Urdu language used in the book.

I hope that the English translation of Maulana Hifzur Rahman's scholarly work will also be of great benefit to the English-speaking people. I just hope that I have been able to do justice to the original thoughts of the author.

Yusuf Karaan
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